bon ‘base, foundation’ plus kaṯ ‘town’, hence ‘chief town, capital’. The town lays at the confluence of the Syr Darya or Jaxartes (which Jovaynī apparently calls ‘the River of Fanākat’) with its right-bank tributary the Āhangarān or Angren (medieval Nahr Īlāq) and at the mouth of the Gijigen valley, hence to the southwest of modern Tashkent; both the ruins of old Banākaṯ and of its replacement Šāhroḵīya have been noted by Russian archaeologists from AD 1896 onwards (Vasilii Vladimirovich Bartol’d, 1977).

Although there is not much information about the coming of Islam to Banākaṯ but local Iranian princes seem to have persisted there into Samanid times, and we have a detailed description in Moqaddesī, of the town in the second half of the 10th century. He calls it the capital of Šāš, with an orthodox Sunni but quarrelsome and turbulent population. There was a citadel (qohandez) with gates opening on to the inner town (madīna) and on to the inner one of the two outer towns (rabaż), where the majority of bāzārs lay; the Friday Mosque was up against the city wall. The town had extensive gardens and orchards and produced “Turkestan” cloth and bows. Four stages to the north lay Asfījāb and the beginning of the Turkish steppes. It was apparently a place of some importance under the Qarakhānids, and coins were minted there under these princes (Jaeckel).

When Genghis Khān’s hordes appeared in Transoxiana, the Qanḡlï Turkish garrison under the Ḵʷārazmšāh’s commander Iletgü Malek defended Banākaṯ for four days against five thousand Mongol troops under Alaq Noyon, Sögetü, and Taqāy. On its surrender, there was a general massacre of the garrison, whilst the male population was impressed into the Mongol forces (ala Ad-din ata Malik Juvaini, 1958). Barthold doubted that it was this event specifically which caused the town’s destruction but opined that it probably fell into ruin in the later 7th /13th century. At any rate, in AD 1392 (year of the monkey), it was rebuilt by Tīmūr and named Šāhroḵīya after his son and successor Šāhroḵ (Yazdī, 1723).

5 ‘Ali-Shir Nava’i was a 15th century politican and polymath with expertise in poetry, politics, linguistics. He was a Hanafi Maturidi and was also known as a fine painter. He was celebrated as being one of the greatest representative of Chagatai literature. He considered that for literary pursuits Chagatai and other Turkic languages were superior to Persian. It was indeed a radical opinion in that era. He posited a view that Turkic vocabulary as being more rich, precise and malleable in comparission to Persian. He brought a work titled ‘Muhakamat al-Lughatayn’ (The Comparison of the Two Languages) with purpose to substantiate his claim of Turkic superiority over the Persian.